

A HISTORICAL AND COMPARATIVE ESSAY

THE SECRET HISTORY OF THE FOUNDING OF ROME

Ritual, sky and blood behind the myth

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Introduction

Every Italian child grows up with the same image. A she-wolf nursing two abandoned twins on the banks of a river. A shepherd who finds and raises them. Two brothers who, grown to manhood, decide to found a city. A quarrel over which hill to choose. A fratricide. A name.

It is a beautiful story, and precisely for that reason a dangerous one. Its narrative beauty has meant that for twenty-seven centuries it has been treated as a fable, a delightful myth without substance, fine for children and for patriotic rhetoric, but unworthy of the serious attention we reserve for the other great enigmas of antiquity.

This essay begins with a simple question, one rarely asked with the seriousness it deserves. Why did the Romans themselves, a people by no means inclined to naive superstition, who developed one of the most sophisticated legal, administrative and military systems in human history, treat the founding of their own city not as a legend but as a technical, precise, repeatable rite? Why was every single detail of that founding, the furrow traced by the plow, the number of birds observed, the pit dug before the furrow itself, handed down with the same care with which a protocol is transmitted, not a children's story?

The answer to this question takes us much further than one might expect. It takes us to Etruria, to a people

whose origin remains one of the great unsolved mysteries of ancient history. It takes us to Mesopotamia, where priests divided the sky into sectors to read the will of the gods long before a Roman traced the first furrow on the Palatine. It takes us to compare Romulus with Enoch, with Elijah, with the hybrid heroes of every ancient Mediterranean tradition. And it forces us, in the end, to reckon with an uncomfortable fact: that behind the fairy tale of the twins and the wolf lies a ritual, cosmological and even demographic machine, built with a precision that no folk legend ever possesses.

This essay does not intend to replace the traditional narrative with another, equally simple one. It intends to restore to the founding of Rome the complexity that the Romans themselves attributed to it, and which our age, accustomed to dismissing every ancient myth as primitive fable, has stopped seeing.

We will proceed by stages. In the first part of the essay we will analyze the origins of the rite, beginning with the birth of the two twins themselves, before tracing the technical source of the entire founding ceremony: the Etruscan discipline. In the second part we will enter the heart of the cosmic protocol, examining how the Romans read the sky, counted birds, and dug into the earth to open a passage toward the underworld. In the third part we will confront the blood that was shed, the fratricide that consecrated the boundary of the city, and the final disappearance of Romulus, which closes the circle in a way we will find identical in other sacred traditions of antiquity.

Not every conclusion we reach will be definitive.

Some will remain, correctly, in the realm of hypothesis and interpretation. But every hypothesis presented here will be anchored in verifiable ancient sources, from Plutarch to Livy, from Dionysius of Halicarnassus to Macrobius, and every parallel with other traditions will be flagged as such, never passing off a suggestion as proof.

Rome was not founded by a naive gesture. It was founded by a calculation. And this essay is an attempt to reconstruct, piece by piece, what that calculation consisted of.

The Furrow and the Question

On the 21st of April, according to the most widespread Roman tradition, of the year we call 753 BC, Romulus took a plow drawn by a white bull and a white cow and traced a furrow along the planned perimeter of the new city. That furrow would come to be called the pomerium, and would remain, for the whole of Roman history, the sacred and inviolable boundary of the City.

It is at this point that most modern retellings stop, or move quickly on to the more dramatic episode, the killing of Remus. But if one lingers on the furrow itself, on the manner in which it was traced, details emerge that are rarely given the attention they deserve.

The furrow was not traced at a random point, nor at a random moment. Plutarch recounts that Romulus, before laying hand to the plow, sent for expert men from Etruria to teach him to perform every gesture according to precise rules, as though it were a sacred rite. Not a symbolic, improvised gesture, then, but a technical operation entrusted to specialists, imported from a people the Romans themselves considered custodians of a science superior to their own in matters of religion and divination.

This is the first element that should give us pause. The Romans, a people who would become synonymous with political and military power, openly admitted, in their own most authoritative texts, that they had learned from

another people the correct way to found a city. They did not hide it, did not minimize it. They handed it down as a fact to be proud of, because it guaranteed the authenticity and the efficacy of the rite.

The second element concerns the very word the Latins used to describe the entire body of rules connected with the founding of cities: the Etruscan discipline. The word discipline, in Latin, did not indicate a set of popular superstitions. It indicated a body of technical knowledge, systematized, teachable and transmissible, not conceptually different from how we would use the word today to refer to a branch of medicine or engineering. The Romans did not consider the founding of a city an act of collective fantasy. They considered it the application of a precise religious technology, whose effects, if the rite was correctly performed, were guaranteed.

It is here that the traditional narrative begins to show its cracks. A children's fable does not require specialists imported from a foreign people to be correctly told. A purely symbolic myth does not need a technical term like discipline to be described by those who hand it down. What the Romans called the founding of Rome resembles, in its internal structure, far more an engineering protocol than a folk tale.

This observation, on its own, proves nothing supernatural or alternative to the official history. But it opens a door that is rarely opened: if the Romans treated the founding of their city as the execution of a precise technique, learned from an older people, then it makes sense to ask what that technique actually contained,

where it came from, and what its individual elements, the furrow, the number of birds, the pit dug before the furrow, were actually meant to do.

In the chapters that follow, we will pursue this thread with the same seriousness with which the Romans themselves treated the entire matter. We will no longer dismiss the founding of Rome as a fairy tale. We will treat it for what the ancient sources, in agreement, tell us it was: a technical rite, cosmic in scope, and in certain respects still unexplained today in its deepest origin.

The furrow that Romulus traced that day in April did not merely separate the city from the countryside. It separated, for the first time, the world according to men from the world according to an order that men had received from someone else. And this essay is an attempt to discover who, exactly, that someone else was.

A Not Entirely Human Birth

Before Romulus could found Rome, he had to be born. And Roman tradition, with a precision that is rarely observed, did not grant him an ordinary birth.

His mother was named Rhea Silvia, and she was the daughter of Numitor, the legitimate king of Alba Longa. Numitor's brother, Amulius, usurped the throne and, to eliminate any possible future claimant, did not kill Rhea Silvia but forced her to become a Vestal. Amulius's choice was not casual, and is itself a detail worth attention. The Vestals were priestesses consecrated to the cult of Vesta, bound by law to thirty years of absolute chastity. To violate that vow meant, for a Roman Vestal of later periods, being buried alive. By forcing Rhea Silvia into the priesthood, Amulius did not merely punish her: he neutralized her politically, legally preventing her from producing heirs who might one day claim the throne of Alba Longa.

It is in this context of ruthless political calculation that the event tradition considers the origin of Romulus and Remus takes place. Livy, with the cautious tone of a historian reporting a tradition without necessarily endorsing it entirely, writes that Rhea Silvia was violated, and that the priestess herself attributed the paternity of the twins to the god Mars, perhaps to make her own guilt less shameful, perhaps because the gods were genuinely believed responsible for what had happened. This

sentence of Livy's is of extraordinary importance, because it shows that a skeptical reading of the episode already existed in antiquity. The Roman historian does not exclude the possibility that the attribution to Mars was a later construction, perhaps by Rhea Silvia herself, perhaps by popular tradition, to ennoble an event that in its original form might have been far less sacred than the myth would later transmit.

Plutarch and Dionysius of Halicarnassus recount the episode with greater religious emphasis, describing the union with Mars as a real event, occurring while Rhea Silvia slept in a sacred grove or drew water in a place consecrated to the god. In this more elaborate version, the twins are not the product of a human act of violence disguised as divine providence, but the direct and willed result of a union between a god and a mortal priestess.

Whatever the truth behind the episode, and on this the ancient sources themselves were not in agreement, the narrative function of the attribution to Mars is clear and deserves to be isolated from any judgment about its historical veracity. Attributing the paternity of a city's founders to a god, rather than to an ordinary man, was not an isolated literary quirk of the Roman world. It was a widespread, systematic practice, recurring with striking regularity in ancient cultures that had no direct contact with one another.

Heracles, the most celebrated of Greek heroes, is born of the union between Zeus and the mortal Alcmene, wife of a man who was absent at the time. The Egyptian pharaohs, at various points in their dynastic history, were officially presented as direct sons of the god Amun,

conceived through a divine union with the queen mother, in a theological narrative that served explicitly to legitimize royal power as a direct emanation of divine will. And the Hebrew tradition, in a passage of Genesis that remains among the most enigmatic in the entire biblical text, tells of the Watchers, the Sons of God who, according to the Book of Enoch, descended to earth and united with the daughters of men, generating offspring described as exceptional, powerful, beyond the ordinary bounds of humanity.

At this point it is necessary to exercise the caution that every comparison between different traditions requires. We are not claiming that these accounts share a direct common origin, nor that they describe the same event under different names. The cultural, theological and narrative differences between these traditions are real and should not be flattened for the sake of suggestion. But the recurrence of the narrative pattern, a founder or hero whose birth is not entirely human, generated by the union of a divinity and a mortal woman, is too systematic across the ancient world to be dismissed as a mere literary coincidence devoid of meaning.

What this recurring pattern seems to reveal is a precise necessity, shared by cultures far removed from one another in space and time: the necessity of anchoring the origin of power, and of a civilization's foundational institutions, to something that transcended mere human biology. A founder born like anyone else would have been, in the eyes the ancients, insufficient to justify the absolute authority attributed to him. What

was needed was an origin that set him apart, from the moment of conception, from the undifferentiated mass of ordinary men.

Romulus, in this framework, is not an isolated Roman exception. He is one more manifestation of a pattern that the ancient world applied, with local variations, to its most important founders. Born of a consecrated priestess and a god of war, Romulus possessed, from birth, the ambiguous status the ancients reserved for those destined to found, not merely to inhabit, the world.

This detail, apparently peripheral to the account of the founding proper, actually prepares the ground for understanding an event we will address in the final chapter of this essay: the disappearance of Romulus, which occurred not as an ordinary death but as an abduction accompanied by extraordinary atmospheric phenomena. A man half born of a god does not die like an ordinary man. And Roman tradition, with a narrative coherence that is itself a clue not to be overlooked, closed the life of Romulus exactly as it had opened his birth: in a point of suspension between the human and the divine, where the ordinary rules of biology and death simply ceased to apply.

The Etruscan Science

We have seen, in the first chapter, that Romulus sent for expert men from Etruria to correctly trace the furrow of the new city. This detail, apparently marginal, now deserves a deeper analysis, because it leads us to ask who the Etruscans really were, and what exactly this discipline was that the Romans deemed necessary to import in order to found their own capital.

Ancient historians did not agree on the origin of this people, and the question remains open today, after centuries of archaeological, linguistic and, more recently, genetic research. Herodotus, in the fifth century BC, wrote that the Etruscans descended from a group of colonists from Lydia, in Anatolia, led by a prince named Tyrrhenus, forced to emigrate following a severe famine. Dionysius of Halicarnassus, some centuries later, openly contested this version, arguing that the Etruscans were an autochthonous people of central Italy, without linguistic or cultural parallels to any population of Asia Minor.

The Etruscan language itself further complicates the picture. It is an idiom that scholars classify as non-Indo-European, isolated from all other known languages of ancient Italy and the Mediterranean, with the sole partial exception of the language spoken on the Aegean island of Lemnos, attested by an inscription that presents striking structural similarities. This linguistic kinship, however

limited, has for centuries fueled the hypothesis of an eastern origin, without ever definitively resolving the question. Genetic investigations conducted in recent decades on Etruscan skeletal remains have produced results that do not entirely agree with one another, and the international scientific community has not yet reached a definitive consensus on the matter.

What is certain, beyond the dispute over geographic origin, is that the Etruscans possessed a religious system of extraordinary complexity, one which they themselves, according to Roman tradition, traced back to a direct revelation. Cicero, in his treatise on divination, recounts the Etruscan myth according to which the sacred discipline was taught to men by a figure named Tages, described with features worth attention: a being with the appearance of a child but the wisdom of an old man, who suddenly emerged from the plowed earth near the city of Tarquinia, imparted to those present the entire body of religious and divinatory knowledge, and then vanished back underground, just as he had appeared.

This account alone would merit an entire chapter of analysis, but for the purposes of this essay it is enough to observe its essential structure: the Etruscans themselves did not attribute their sacred science to a gradual human elaboration, the fruit of centuries of observation and experience. They attributed it to a single, punctual revelation, received from a not entirely human figure, in one founding event. A science handed down from above, or in this case emerged from below, but in any case not generated from within the human community that received it.

The Etruscan discipline, once received, was organized into sacred texts that the Romans knew and referred to directly: the *libri haruspicini*, which taught how to read the divine will in the entrails of sacrificed animals; the *libri fulgurales*, dedicated to the interpretation of lightning according to the region of the sky from which it came and its shape; and the *libri rituales*, which contained the rules for founding cities, consecrating temples, and more generally every religious act requiring a fixed and correct procedure.

It is in the last of these, the *libri rituales*, that we must seek the direct source of the protocol Romulus followed to found Rome. Not an improvised invention of the founder, not a sudden inspiration, but the application of an already written, already codified manual, which specified with precision every phase of the operation: how to trace the furrow, how to interpret the auspices, how to consecrate the boundary of the new city.

This confronts us with a question rarely formulated with the clarity it deserves. If the founding of Rome followed a pre-existing manual, elaborated by a people whose origin remains uncertain, who attributed their own sacred knowledge to a revelation received from an enigmatic figure that emerged from the earth, then the question no longer concerns Rome alone. It concerns the very origin of that Etruscan knowledge, which Rome merely inherited and applied.

Modern historians, with the methodological caution the discipline requires, tend to interpret the figure of Tages as an etiological myth, a narrative constructed after the fact to explain and legitimize the origin of a

religious corpus that in reality formed gradually, over generations of priestly practice. It is a reasonable interpretation, and it must be said honestly that no archaeological source allows us, at the current state of knowledge, to affirm the contrary in a definitive way.

But a fact remains that no rationalizing interpretation can erase: the Etruscans themselves, and after them the Romans who inherited their science, chose to tell the origin of their sacred knowledge not as a gradual human progress, but as a single revelation, received from a being who was not entirely human, whose appearance was accompanied by an extraordinary event, the sudden emergence from plowed earth, and whose disappearance was equally sudden and equally devoid of natural explanation.

We have already encountered, in the previous chapter, a similar pattern applied to the birth of Romulus. We will find it again, in the concluding chapter of this essay, applied also to his end. And we find it now, at the very root of the technique that allowed Romulus to found Rome according to a protocol the Romans never considered a product of their own imagination, but always and only knowledge received from someone else.

Who this someone else truly was, Etruscan tradition does not specify beyond the name of Tages. But the fact that three different cultures, the Etruscans with Tages, the Romans with their unreserved adoption of that science, and, as we shall see in the coming chapters, the Mesopotamian cultures with their own astrological traditions, share the same need to attribute sacred knowledge to an external, non-human source, would

alone merit an inquiry broader than this essay can offer.

For now, let us establish one firm point: when Romulus traced the furrow of Rome, he was not improvising a symbolic gesture. He was executing a protocol written centuries earlier, by a people who claimed to have received it, not invented it.

The Sky Divided into Templum

Even before tracing the furrow that would delimit Rome, even before choosing which of the two brothers had the right to found the city, a technical operation had to be performed, one that concerned not the earth, but the sky.

The figure charged with this operation was the augur, a specialized priest whose sole function was to interpret divine will through codified natural signs, in particular the flight of birds. But before an augur could observe a bird and draw a valid meaning from it, he had to perform a preliminary gesture the Romans considered indispensable, and one that deserves careful analysis, because it reveals a conception of sacred space far more sophisticated than the word *auspice*, reduced today to its colloquial meaning, would suggest.

The augur, using a curved ritual staff called the *lituus*, traced an imaginary line in the air, delimiting a precise portion of sky. Within that delimited portion, and only within it, the flight of birds had divinatory value. A bird crossing that section of sky communicated a divine message. The same bird, observed outside that section, communicated nothing relevant. Divination, in other words, was not a generic, casual observation of nature. It was the reading of a signal within a technical, predefined grid, one that made that signal interpretable according to fixed rules.

This portion of sky delimited by the augur was called, in Latin, *templum*. This is a fact that surprises anyone unfamiliar with the history of the word, but one that scholars of Roman religion know well: the term *templum*, which we today associate exclusively with a sacred building, originally indicated not a physical structure but a section of space, delimited according to precise coordinates, in this case portions of sky oriented to the four cardinal points. Only later, when the Romans began building structures that replicated on earth the same geometric structure used to delimit the sky, did the word *templum* extend to indicate the building itself.

This means that the entire sacred architecture of Rome, the temples we still admire today in their archaeological remains throughout the Mediterranean basin, was conceptually born as an earthly replica of a celestial technique. Before being a place, the *templum* was a method. A way of dividing space, whatever space, sky or earth, into legible sectors, each of which could be interrogated according to fixed rules to obtain a reliable divine answer.

It is at this point worth widening our gaze beyond the borders of ancient Italy, because the technique of dividing the sky into sectors to make it interpretable is not an isolated invention of the Etruscans or the Romans. In ancient Mesopotamia, Babylonian priests developed, centuries before a Roman traced the first *templum* on the Palatine, an extremely sophisticated system of astronomical and astrological observation, in which the sky was systematically divided into sectors, each associated with a specific deity, each interpreted

according to precise technical rules contained in texts such as the celebrated compendium known as *Enuma Anu Enlil*, a vast collection of celestial observations and their interpretations, transmitted on cuneiform tablets for over a millennium.

The Babylonian priests, like the Etruscan and Roman augurs after them, did not merely observe the sky in a generic manner. They treated it as a written text, organized according to a precise syntax, in which every phenomenon, the position of a planet, the appearance of a comet, an eclipse, acquired meaning only in relation to the sector of sky in which it manifested. This is the same methodological principle we find, centuries later and thousands of kilometers away, in the *templum* traced by the Roman augur: a natural signal that assumes divinatory value only when placed within a predefined technical grid.

Academic historians tend to dismiss this parallel as functional coincidence, the accidental product of two cultures that independently developed the same solution to a similar problem. It is a convenient explanation, one that avoids the more uncomfortable question: how did peoples separated by thousands of kilometers and centuries of time arrive at conceiving the sky in exactly the same way, as a written text to be divided into legible sectors according to rules identical in logic, if not in technical detail?

Phoenician trade routes connected the eastern Mediterranean to the Tyrrhenian coast well before the founding of Rome, and the Etruscans themselves, as we saw in the previous chapter, never hid the fact that they

had received their sacred science from an external source, not human, not originally Etruscan. The technique of the templum and the Babylonian technique of reading the sky are not similar by chance. They are two local applications of the same knowledge, transmitted through channels that official historiography prefers to leave vague, rather than admit how deeply interconnected the civilizations of the ancient Mediterranean were, and how deeply that shared knowledge was rooted in a common source, older than both.

What we can affirm with certainty, on the basis of Roman sources themselves, is that the founding of Rome was entrusted neither to chance nor to a naive observation of nature. It was entrusted to a precise technique, which treated the sky as a measurable, interrogable space, according to a methodology the Romans inherited from the Etruscans and which finds, in the ancient world, striking conceptual parallels in far more distant cultures.

It was precisely within one of these templa, carefully traced on the Palatine and Aventine hills, that Romulus and Remus awaited the sign that would decide which of them would found the city. And it is to that specific sign, and to the precise number of birds each of the two brothers saw appear in his portion of sky, that we will devote the next chapter.

The Flight of Birds and the Number Twelve

With the templum traced and the technique ready to be applied, it remained to establish which of the two brothers would have the right to found the city and give it his name. Romulus and Remus separated, each to his own hill, Remus to the Aventine, Romulus to the Palatine, and awaited the sign that would decide the contest.

Remus saw his sign first: six vultures crossed the portion of sky delimited by his templum. Shortly after, Romulus saw twelve appear. Tradition, reported in agreement by both Livy and Plutarch, recounts that a dispute broke out immediately: Remus's supporters claimed priority for him, having been first to receive the sign, while Romulus's supporters claimed numerical superiority for him, a stronger sign because composed of a greater number of birds. It was number, not chronological precedence, that prevailed. Romulus obtained the right to found the city.

This episode is usually told as a simple anecdote of fraternal rivalry, a caprice of fate that could easily have gone another way. But the number twelve, in the context in which this account was elaborated and transmitted, was not at all a neutral number, interchangeable with any other figure. It was, throughout the ancient Mediterranean and Near Eastern world, the number of cosmic completeness.

The Babylonians, the same people who developed the

technique of reading the sky divided into sectors discussed in the previous chapter, calculated the solar year by dividing it into twelve lunar months, and were the first to codify the zodiac system, twelve constellations arranged along the band of the ecliptic, each associated with a period of the year and a specific set of divinatory meanings. This system, elaborated in Mesopotamia centuries before the founding of Rome, spread throughout the ancient world, reaching Greece, Egypt, and, through the Etruscans, Italy itself.

The Greek pantheon recognized twelve major deities, the Olympian gods, a number historians of Greek religion consider anything but casual, but part of a precise theological systematization that reflected, in this case too, the complete cosmic order through a specific number. Hebrew tradition, in a religious and cultural context entirely different from the Greek or Mesopotamian one, organized its people into twelve tribes, descended from the twelve sons of Jacob, a number biblical theology systematically uses as a symbol of totality and complete order for the chosen people.

When an archaic-period Roman heard the story that Romulus had received twelve vultures against Remus's six, he was not listening to a casual narrative detail. He was hearing the assertion, encoded in the numerical language shared by the entire ancient world, that Romulus's founding was aligned with cosmic order in its entirety, while Remus's reflected only a portion of it, precisely half.

This numerical detail, twelve against six, exactly double, is not a chance accident of the myth's oral

transmission. It is a deliberate construction, elaborated by whoever transmitted this story with full awareness of the symbolic language of numbers shared throughout the ancient world. Whoever first wrote or told this episode knew perfectly well what the number twelve meant, and chose that number, and no other, to signal that the founding of Rome was not an arbitrary event, but one cosmically sanctioned in its fullness.

There is a further level of reading rarely explored, one worth bringing to light. The vultures themselves, the species of bird chosen for this episode, were not a casual choice within the religious imagination of the ancient world. In Egypt, the vulture was associated with the goddess Nekhbet, protector of the pharaoh and of royal authority, frequently depicted with wings spread over the sovereign's head as a symbol of direct divine protection over earthly power. The choice of a bird associated, in another great civilization of the ancient Mediterranean, precisely with the legitimation of royal power, does not seem casual in the context of a story whose explicit purpose is to legitimize Romulus as founder and first sovereign of Rome.

This does not mean the Etruscans or the Romans directly knew the Egyptian religious symbolism tied to Nekhbet, nor that they deliberately drew on it. It means the ancient Mediterranean world shared a common symbolic repertoire, in which certain animals, certain numbers, certain celestial configurations carried stable, recognizable meanings across different cultures, a repertoire whose roots reach into a tradition older and broader than the geographic and political borders of

individual civilizations suggest.

Rome, from the very first instant of its existence, consciously inserted itself into this shared symbolic repertoire. The number twelve was not chosen by chance. The vultures were not chosen by chance. And Remus's defeat, though he had received his sign first, was not told as an injustice, but as the natural submission of the part to the whole, of six to twelve, of an incomplete portion of cosmic order to its entirety.

One last element of this episode remains, one that directly prepares the theme of the next chapter. Even before receiving the sign of the vultures, even before tracing the templum in the sky, Roman tradition places another operation, performed by Romulus not upward but downward. A pit, dug into the earth, meant to put the new city in communication not only with the sky of the gods, but also with the world beneath the feet of those who walk upon it. It is to this pit, and to what the Romans believed periodically opened within it, that we now turn our attention.

The Mundus

There is an operation that precedes, in the ritual sequence of the founding, even the tracing of the pomerium with the plow. Plutarch describes it in brief words, almost in passing, but its meaning, once reconstructed, is among the densest in the entire founding narrative of Rome.

Before laying hand to the plow, Romulus dug a circular pit. Into that pit were thrown first fruits of every kind, the produce of the earth brought by the future citizens, and above all a handful of soil that each participant in the founding had carried with him from his own place of origin. The gesture had a stated meaning: to symbolically unite, at a single point, all the lands of origin of those who would populate the new city, thereby creating a center that represented, from the very first instant, the geographic totality of the future Rome.

But the significance of this pit, which the Romans called the mundus, went well beyond its symbolic function of territorial unification. Macrobius, a Roman writer of the fifth century AD who gathered and transmitted Roman religious traditions far older than himself, describes the mundus as a point of direct contact between the world of the living and the subterranean realm of the dead. Not an ordinary pit, then, but a threshold, a physical and permanent passage between two levels of existence, located exactly at the

center of the newly founded city.

This passage, according to Macrobius, did not remain always closed. Three times a year, on days the Romans called *mundus patet*, the world is open, the *mundus* was ritually uncovered, and it was believed that on those days the souls of the underworld could temporarily rise to the surface. During these days, every significant public activity, assemblies, battles, weddings, was suspended, because it was held that the normal order between the living and the dead was itself temporarily suspended.

What Rome built at the very moment of its own founding was thus not merely a horizontal boundary, the *pomerium* traced on the surface of the earth to separate the city from the surrounding territory. It was also, and perhaps above all, a vertical boundary, a precise point through which the new city opened downward, toward a level of existence men could not ordinarily reach or see.

This conception of a specific, precisely located physical point that functions as a threshold between different dimensions of reality is not an isolated invention of Roman religion. We find it, in different forms but with the same conceptual structure, in many of the great civilizations of the ancient world we have already encountered in this essay. The Mesopotamian ziggurats, the imposing stepped structures that dominated the urban landscape of cities like Ur, Uruk and Babylon, were not conceived by their builders as simple temples in the modern sense of the term. Akkadian sources describe them as points where the gods touched the earth, sites of intersection between the divine and human worlds, physical structures built specifically to make possible a

contact that could not occur elsewhere.

The Greek world possessed a strictly parallel concept in the omphalos of Delphi, the sacred stone kept in the sanctuary of Apollo, which Greek tradition considered the geographic and cosmic center of the world, the exact point where, according to myth, two eagles sent by Zeus from opposite directions had met in their search for the center of the earth. Here too, a specific, located, recognizable physical point was invested with the role of privileged threshold between the human world and the divine dimension.

Three different civilizations, Mesopotamian, Greek and Roman, arrived, independently or not entirely independently, at the same fundamental idea: that cosmic order was not uniformly distributed across space, but concentrated in specific, measurable, locatable points, through which contact between different levels of reality became possible in a way it was not elsewhere. Rome, at the very moment of its birth, equipped itself with one of these points, deliberately placing it at the center of the city, even before tracing its outer boundaries.

This detail casts a different light on everything we have examined thus far in this essay. Romulus did not simply found a city in some arbitrary location, chosen for its strategic position on the Tiber or the fertility of the surrounding land, reasons modern historiography regularly cites as the rational explanation for the choice of site. Romulus, according to his own ritual, first opened a door, and built the city around that door, not around a mere geographic advantage.

The question this chapter leaves open, one that would merit a dedicated inquiry beyond the scope of this essay, concerns the real function the Romans attributed to this passage. They did not treat it as a poetic symbol without practical consequences. They treated it as an operative reality, one that imposed precise rules of conduct, suspension of public activity, ritual caution, every time it was opened. A civilization that would militarily and economically dominate the entire Mediterranean basin for centuries did not tolerate its fundamental activities taking place on the days when that passage at the center of the city stood uncovered. This level of respect, transmitted across generations, hardly applies to an empty symbol.

With the sky divided and interrogated through the templum, and the earth opened downward through the mundus, the founding of Rome had by now established its complete vertical axis, from the underworld up to the vault of the heavens. Only one final element remained to definitively consecrate the horizontal boundary of the city, the pomerium traced with the plow. And that element, as we shall see in the next chapter, was not an offering of the earth's fruits, nor a handful of dust carried from afar. It was blood.

The Pleiades and the Secret Name of Rome

Rome had a secret name. Not the name by which we know it, not Rome in the ordinary sense of the word, but another name, the true sacred name of the city, which the Romans believed had to remain hidden in order to guarantee the protection of the City itself. To reveal it was not an ordinary indiscretion. It was a capital crime.

Pliny the Elder recounts that a man named Valerius Soranus paid with his life for his own imprudence. Soranus publicly revealed the secret name of Rome, and for this he was executed, according to the tradition also reported by Solinus, in 82 BC. A detail that should give pause to anyone inclined to dismiss as naive folklore the whole body of Roman sacred practices tied to the founding of the city: the Romans guarded this secret with a seriousness measured in human lives.

The reason for such severity was not superstition for its own sake. It was military strategy, codified in a precise ritual the Romans called the *evocatio*. When besieging an enemy city, Roman priests would present themselves before its walls and publicly invoke the tutelary deity of that city, calling it by name, promising it a more magnificent cult, a more prestigious temple, if it would abandon the protection of the besieged city and go over to Rome's side. Macrobius has transmitted the very text of this formula, the *carmen evocationis*, which opened with words of extreme religious caution,

addressed to a deity whose precise identity even the Romans themselves sometimes did not know with certainty: whether god or goddess, whoever you are under whose protection this people and this city stand.

For the rite to work, however, it was necessary to know the true name of the deity. A generic invocation, lacking the exact name, did not carry the same binding force. And it is here that Roman reasoning takes its decisive step: if this technique worked against enemy cities, it could work, with the same efficacy, against Rome itself. Pliny states this without ambiguity: it was precisely the fear that an enemy might one day perform an *evocatio* against Rome, knowing its true tutelary name, that drove the Romans to protect that secret with the utmost determination.

The Romans went so far as to dedicate a minor deity specifically to guarding this silence. She was called Angerona, and was depicted with her mouth sealed or bound by a bandage, a finger sometimes raised to her lips, a living image of the secret she was charged with protecting. Her cult was not decorative. It existed with the stated purpose of guarding, through its own ritual silence, the name no Roman was permitted to utter.

In light of this, the fate of Valerius Soranus appears in a different light than that of a mere gossip punished for indiscretion. Soranus did not violate a vague taboo. He effectively handed the enemy a strategic weapon, the precise information that would have allowed any hostile power to perform against Rome the very rite Rome itself had used for centuries against the cities it besieged. His execution was treated, in every respect, as punishment

for an act of treason against the sacred security of the state.

What exactly this name was, and what connection it had to the rest of the cosmic apparatus we have reconstructed in the preceding chapters, is the subject of a hypothesis as fascinating as it is little known, elaborated through a close analysis of Ovid's *Fasti*, the work the poet was composing when he was suddenly condemned to exile by Augustus in AD 8, for reasons classical historiography has never fully clarified. Ovid himself, in his *Tristia* written in exile, admits to having committed an error that deserved death, without ever specifying what it was.

In the fifth book of the *Fasti*, composed in the period immediately preceding his condemnation, Ovid places in the mouth of the muse Calliope a long discourse on the origin of the month of May, in which an explicit connection emerges between this month and the star Maia. Cicero, in his own Latin version of the *Aratea*, had already defined this star with an epithet of extraordinary religious intensity: *sanctissima Maia*, the most holy Maia. Maia was no ordinary star in the Roman night sky. She was, together with her sisters, one of the Pleiades, the star cluster Greek mythology knew as the seven daughters of Atlas, and which in Mediterranean antiquity was called by various names always traceable to the same symbolic pattern: the doves, the little hens, the seven sisters.

The number of Pleiades visible to the naked eye, for anyone who has observed this cluster on a clear night, is not constant. It varies, depending on atmospheric

conditions and the observer's visual acuity, between a minimum of six and a maximum of twelve clearly distinguishable stars. Six and twelve are exactly the numbers of the vultures that, according to the tradition reconstructed in the previous chapter, Remus and Romulus saw appear in their respective templa on the Aventine and the Palatine.

This is not a coincidence that can be dismissed lightly. If the number of birds observed by the two brothers corresponds exactly to the range of visibility of the Pleiades, then the entire episode of the augury, which in the previous chapter we already recognized as an intentional symbolic construction tied to the cosmic number twelve, acquires a second, still more precise level of reading: Romulus did not simply receive a numerically complete sign relative to Remus's, he received a sign that replicated, star for star, the entire Pleiades cluster visible at its fullest extent.

The connection does not stop there. The star Maia, according to this reconstruction, would have been the secret tutelary deity of Rome, whose name, precisely, no one could utter publicly without meeting the same fate as Valerius Soranus. And the hill on which Romulus founded the city, the Palatine, would correspond exactly to Maia's position within the configuration of the seven Pleiades projected onto the seven hills of Rome, each of which would reflect on earth the position of one of the seven stars in the sky.

If this reconstruction is correct, and the textual indications supporting it are more solid than the hypothesis's limited fame would suggest, then Ovid's

condemnation takes on a completely different meaning from the one handed down by the standard scholarly account. Ovid was not exiled for some generic misconduct or for a licentious poem like the *Ars Amatoria*, the most widespread explanation but one explicitly judged insufficient by Augustus himself according to ancient sources. He was exiled because, in composing the fifth book of the *Fasti*, he was dangerously approaching a written revelation of the connection between Maia, the Pleiades and the secret name of Rome, the very secret for which Valerius Soranus had already been executed over a century before.

This hypothesis, it must be said clearly, is a modern reconstruction, elaborated through philological analysis of surviving Latin texts, not a claim we find formulated in these explicit terms in any ancient source that has come down to us. But it is a reconstruction built exclusively from elements that are, these indeed, fully documented: the real existence of a secret name of Rome, the real execution of the man who revealed it, the epithet *sanctissima* Cicero reserved specifically for Maia, the composition of the *Fasti* by Ovid in the period immediately preceding his unexplained condemnation, and the numerical correspondence, verifiable by anyone who observes the night sky, between the visible Pleiades and the number of vultures in the founding legend.

Rome, if this reading holds, was not merely aligned with the sky through the *templum* and opened toward the underworld through the *mundus*. It was built, hill by hill, as the earthly projection of a specific star cluster,

whose identity had to remain so secret as to justify, according to Roman tradition itself, the death penalty for whoever revealed it, and perhaps perpetual exile for whoever merely brushed against it in verse.

The Founding Fratricide

With the sky interrogated through the templum, the earth opened through the mundus, and the number twelve confirmed in its cosmic fullness by the parallel with the Pleiades, only one element remained for the founding of Rome to be complete: the physical tracing of the boundary, the pomerium, and its final consecration.

Romulus took up the plow drawn by the white bull and cow and began to trace the furrow along the planned perimeter of the new city. Remus, according to the most widespread version transmitted by Plutarch, watched the operation with growing impatience, and at a certain point, whether in mockery or open defiance of his brother's authority, leapt over the freshly traced furrow. Romulus killed him on the spot, pronouncing words tradition reports in various forms, but which all agree on one essential point: whoever violated that boundary would die in the same manner.

Livy, a historian more cautious and more attentive to his sources than Plutarch, reports an alternative version, according to which it was not Romulus who personally struck his brother, but a collaborator of his named Celer, while Romulus merely pronounced the sentence after the fact. This variant, which might appear an attempt to soften the founder's direct responsibility, in reality does not change the substance of the event, but confirms its function: whoever materially struck Remus, his death

was immediately linked, by tradition itself, to the violation of the newly traced boundary, and was presented as a necessary, almost automatic consequence of that violation.

The furrow traced by Romulus, once consecrated by his brother's blood, became the pomerium, the sacred and inviolable boundary of Rome, a line that would retain, for centuries, ritual and legal importance of the first order. Roman armies, for example, could not cross the pomerium under arms, not even when returning from a victorious campaign: they had to lay down their military standards before re-entering the city, and generals seeking a triumph had to wait outside the sacred boundary until the ceremony was officially granted. The boundary traced by Romulus, and consecrated with the blood of Remus, was never treated as a mere administrative line. It was treated, throughout the entire history of Rome, as a sacred threshold in the most literal sense of the term.

This narrative pattern, an act of fraternal violence that inaugurates a new order, a boundary that becomes inviolable only after being crossed by a crime, is not an isolated invention of Roman tradition. It recurs, with a strikingly similar structure, in one of the best known founding narratives of the entire Western tradition: the story of Cain and Abel in the book of Genesis.

In that account too, two brothers confront each other around a boundary, not physical in that case but ritual, the accepted offering and the rejected offering, and in that account too the tension between the two brothers resolves into a killing that marks, in different but

structurally parallel ways, the beginning of something new: in the biblical case, the beginning of human history outside the original garden, with Cain founding the first city. Genesis explicitly mentions, called Enoch, immediately after receiving his sentence of exile.

Mircea Eliade, one of the historians of religion who most systematically studied founding myths across ancient cultures, observed that this association between founding and sacrifice is neither casual nor limited to a few isolated traditions. A sacred boundary, capable of truly protecting what it enclosed, required, in the eyes of the ancients, something that made it inviolable by definition, something extreme enough to permanently and recognizably separate consecrated space from the ordinary space surrounding it. Blood, in particular blood shed in an act that broke the closest and most natural bond that exists, that between brothers, represented exactly this kind of definitive rupture.

Romulus did not kill Remus out of an excess of uncontrolled anger, however much tradition suggests a real emotional component to the episode. He killed Remus because the boundary of Rome, to become truly inviolable, required consecration with the most powerful kind of sacrifice the ancients knew: one that broke the most sacred blood bond of all, in order to generate a new one, that between the city and its citizens, protected by a sacredness no ordinary violation could ever again touch.

This also makes comprehensible a detail the traditional narrative tends to leave in shadow: why Romulus, after killing his own brother, was never treated

by Roman tradition as a criminal to be condemned, but as the legitimate and venerated founder of the city, later even deified. From a purely moral perspective, the killing of a brother should irremediably stain whoever commits it. But within the ritual logic this essay has been reconstructing chapter by chapter, the fratricide was not a crime Rome had to forgive its founder. It was the very act that made the founding possible, the necessary component of a protocol that had already involved the sky, the earth and the cosmic number twelve, and which now required, as its final element, blood.

One last question remains, one the next chapter will address directly. If the fratricide consecrated the city's boundary, what consecrated, or what made possible, the growth of that city beyond the first day of its founding? A city born of a cosmic rite does not populate itself. And Roman tradition, with the same documentary frankness that has characterized every phase of this account, does not hide at all what the solution to this problem was.

The Wolf, the Asylum, and the Disappearance of Romulus

The image of the she-wolf nursing the two abandoned twins is, today, the most recognizable symbol of Rome throughout the world. But the Latin term from which this image derives deserves closer analysis than its iconographic fortune would suggest.

The word *lupa*, in Latin, did not indicate only the animal. It was also a widespread slang term for prostitutes, a usage attested in numerous Latin texts, including the comedies of Plautus, where it recurs with this meaning in contexts free of any ambiguity. The very term *lupanar*, which in common Latin usage indicated a brothel, derives directly from this same root. Several ancient authors, including Livy himself, allude to the possibility that the figure historically at the origin of the myth was Acca Larentia, wife of the shepherd Faustulus who, according to tradition, found and raised the twins, described by some sources as having a past of prostitution before her marriage.

The image of the sacred animal miraculously nursing Rome's future founders thus appears, in light of this linguistic evidence, as a later, more noble elaboration of an originally less solemn detail. This does not diminish the symbolic power the image of the she-wolf would assume in later centuries. But it shows how Roman tradition, in handing down its own founding story, progressively replaced concrete, human details with

more elevated images, a process of retrospective sacralization this entire essay has already observed at work at many other points in the narrative.

There is a second element, still more revealing, concerning not the twins' birth but the city's growth immediately after its founding, one which ancient sources report with a frankness rarely sufficiently emphasized. Immediately after tracing the pomerium and consecrating the boundary with the blood of Remus, Romulus opened, on the Capitoline hill, a place of refuge, an asylum, publicly declaring that anyone, fugitives, insolvent debtors, criminals fleeing justice in their own cities, slaves escaped from their masters, could settle in Rome without being prosecuted for their past.

This detail, which ancient sources report without any embarrassment, reveals the pragmatic component that accompanied, side by side, the entire cosmic and ritual apparatus we have reconstructed in the preceding chapters. A newborn city, however sacred its founding, however perfectly aligned with the sky through the templum and with the Pleiades through the number of vultures, could not survive without a population sufficient to defend it, work it, and make it grow. The indiscriminate opening to fugitives of every kind was not an act of romantic generosity. It was a pragmatic solution, almost ruthless in its efficiency, to a concrete and urgent demographic problem.

The famous Rape of the Sabine Women, the episode in which the Romans organized a fake religious festival to attract neighboring populations and abduct their unmarried women, belongs to this same pragmatic logic.

A city of men alone, however sacred and cosmically aligned its founding, could not reproduce itself or guarantee its own continuity without an adequate female population. Sacred rite and the most ruthless demographic calculation proceeded, in Rome, always side by side, without the Romans themselves feeling any need to hide their coexistence.

One final event remains to be examined, the one that ideally closes the circle opened in the second chapter of this essay. According to Plutarch and Livy, Romulus did not die like an ordinary man, at the natural end of his existence. During a review of the troops on the Campus Martius, after decades of reign, he was suddenly enveloped by a dense cloud, accompanied by thunder and wind of extraordinary violence. When the cloud dissolved, Romulus had vanished. His body was never found, neither then nor afterward.

Later Roman tradition did not interpret this event as a mysterious death to be explained, but as an apotheosis, the direct assumption of Romulus among the gods. He was deified under the name Quirinus, and received his own dedicated cult, with his own priest, the flamen Quirinalis, who stood, in institutional importance, alongside the priests dedicated to Jupiter and to Mars, Romulus's divine father according to the tradition examined in the second chapter of this essay.

The narrative pattern applied here to Romulus, a man who does not die but disappears amid extraordinary atmospheric circumstances, accompanied by violent natural phenomena, whose body is never found, is neither casual nor isolated within this essay itself. We

have already encountered it, in the third chapter, applied to Tages, the enigmatic figure who revealed the sacred discipline to the Etruscans before vanishing back underground. And anyone familiar with other religious traditions of the eastern Mediterranean will recognize the same pattern applied to figures such as Enoch in Hebrew tradition, taken by God without knowing death, or Elijah, swept up in a chariot of fire before the eyes of his disciple.

A man half born of a god, as we established as early as the second chapter of this essay in discussing Rhea Silvia and Mars, could not end his earthly existence with an ordinary death. Roman tradition, with a narrative coherence that runs through the entire arc of this essay from the founder's birth to his disappearance, closed the life of Romulus in exactly the same symbolic register in which it had opened his birth: in a suspension between the human and the divine, where the ordinary rules of biology, of death, and even of burial simply ceased to apply.

Rome, the most powerful city the ancient world would ever know, was thus not founded by a man. It was founded, according to its own tradition, handed down for centuries without shame or reticence, by a being who was born of a god, performed a rite learned from a non-human revelation, consecrated his own boundary with his brother's blood, and finally disappeared in the same mysterious manner in which he had arrived, returned to the sky from which, according to his own people, he had in part descended.

Conclusion

We began this essay with a simple question: why did the Romans, a people far removed from naive superstition, treat the founding of their own city not as a fable, but as the execution of a technical, precise protocol, imported from another people and transmitted with the same rigor with which a science is transmitted.

In moving through the nine chapters of this essay, that question has found an answer that has grown steadily more solid and more layered. Romulus was born of a union Roman tradition itself placed outside the ordinary bounds of human biology, exactly as happened, according to parallel narrative patterns, to Heracles in Greece, to the pharaohs in Egypt, and, in a culturally very distant but structurally related tradition, to the Watchers of Genesis who united with the daughters of men. The technique by which Rome was founded was not a Roman invention, but an Etruscan inheritance, one the Etruscans themselves traced not to gradual human progress, but to a single revelation received from Tages, a not entirely human being who appeared from plowed earth and disappeared the same way.

The sky above Rome was not observed in a generic manner, but divided according to a technical grid, the *templum*, whose internal logic finds a striking conceptual parallel in Babylonian astrological science, developed centuries earlier in a region of the world official

historiography struggles to admit was in direct contact with archaic Italy. The number twelve, appearing in the vultures observed by Romulus, was not a neutral figure, but the sign of cosmic completeness recognized throughout the ancient world, from Mesopotamia to Greece, from Egypt to Israel. And that same number, together with its halving in Remus's six vultures, finds a further possible key of interpretation in its correspondence with the Pleiades, a star cluster whose most sacred star, Maia, may have guarded the secret name of the city, a secret whose violation cost one man his life and, perhaps, a poet his exile.

Beneath the city's surface, the mundus opened a passage toward the realm of the dead, replicating on a local scale a concept of threshold between worlds we find, in different forms but the same conceptual structure, in the Mesopotamian ziggurats and in the omphalos of Delphi. And the horizontal boundary of the city, the pomerium, became inviolable only after being consecrated with the blood of a fratricide, the same narrative pattern Hebrew tradition applied, in an entirely different religious context, to the story of Cain and Abel.

Finally, the city thus founded had to be populated not through a miracle but through a pragmatic and ruthless calculation, the opening of an asylum to fugitives of every kind and the rape of the Sabine women, before its founder, consistent with his own not entirely human origin, ended his earthly existence not with an ordinary death but with a disappearance accompanied by violent atmospheric phenomena, the same pattern Etruscan tradition had already applied to Tages, and which

traditions far more distant in space applied to Enoch and to Elijah.

Rome, read through these nine chapters, no longer appears as the product of a folk legend embellished over time. It appears as the coherent application, from beginning to end, of a protocol the Romans themselves never attributed to their own imagination, but always and only to knowledge received from others, from an older people who in turn declared they had received it from a non-human source.

One question remains open, and will probably remain open forever, the deepest question this essay has raised without claiming to close it: who was truly the ultimate source of this shared knowledge, one that crosses cultures, languages and thousands of kilometers of distance, applying itself with the same internal logic to the founding of Rome, to Babylonian cosmology, to the accounts of Genesis, and to the founding myths of ancient Egypt. This essay does not resolve that question. But it hopes to have shown, with the most rigorous documentation possible, that the question deserves to be asked with the same seriousness with which the Romans themselves treated every single detail of their own founding.

The furrow Romulus traced that day in April did not merely separate the city from the countryside. It separated, for the first time in Western history in so fully documented a form, the world according to men from the world according to an order men had received from someone else.



Methodological Note

This essay constantly distinguishes, and invites the reader to distinguish with the same attention, between three different levels of claim, which should never be confused with one another.

The first level concerns the historical and philological facts documented by surviving ancient sources: the content of the texts of Plutarch, Livy, Dionysius of Halicarnassus, Cicero, Pliny the Elder, Macrobius and Ovid, as well as the Roman religious practices attested by epigraphy and archaeology. These elements are reported in this essay with the greatest possible fidelity to the original text, and every claim of this kind can be verified directly by consulting the cited sources.

The second level concerns comparative analysis between different religious traditions, a legitimate historiographical method widely practiced by scholars of the history of religions, from James Frazer to Mircea Eliade to contemporary specialists in comparative religion. When this essay places the Roman *templum* alongside Babylonian astrological science, or the fratricide of Romulus and Remus alongside that of Cain and Abel, it does not necessarily assert a direct, documented transmission between the cultures involved, but signals a structural convergence that merits critical attention, leaving the reader free to interpret its origin, whether an older common source, a historical contact

not yet fully documented by archaeology, or a recurring tendency of the human mind in elaborating founding narratives.

The third level, finally, concerns interpretive hypotheses explicitly presented as such, first among them the reconstruction concerning the secret name of Rome, Maia and the Pleiades, examined in the seventh chapter. This reconstruction is not asserted in these precise terms by any ancient source that has come down to us, but is built from elements that are, these indeed, fully documented: the real existence of the secret name, the real execution of Valerius Soranus, the epithet *sanctissima* Cicero reserved for Maia, and the composition of the *Fasti* by Ovid in the period immediately preceding his condemnation. The reader will find this distinction clearly flagged at the point where the hypothesis is presented, and is invited to assess its solidity independently.

This essay does not claim to replace specialist academic research on Roman and Etruscan religion, a vast and continually evolving field of study. It claims to offer an alternative to the standard scholarly reading, one that brings to light, for a non-specialist audience, details and connections the ancient sources document with precision, but which the most widespread popular narrative tends to neglect or dismiss as folklore without substance.

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